

# RMIT University

## Assignment Cover Page (INDIVIDUAL)

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| <b>Subject Code:</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | COMM2633                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| <b>Subject Name:</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | Popular Culture in Every                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| <b>Location &amp; Campus where you study:</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | Melbourne                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| <b>Title of Assignment:</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | Written Reflection on Popular Culture                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
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| <b>Group Number:</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
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| <b>Number of pages including this one:</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | 04                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>Word Count:</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | 538                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Declaration of Authorship:</b><br>Make sure to read the <a href="https://www.rmit.edu.au/students/studentessentials/assessment-and-exams/assessment/assessment-declaration">Assessment Declaration</a><br><a href="https://www.rmit.edu.au/students/studentessentials/assessment-and-exams/assessment/assessment-declaration">https://www.rmit.edu.au/students/studentessentials/assessment-and-exams/assessment/assessment-declaration</a> | I declare that in submitting all work for this assessment I have read, understood and agree to the content and expectations of the <a href="#">Assessment declaration</a> .<br><a href="#">Links to an external site.</a>                                                                                                      |
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Takacs and Stacy (2015) propose that the meaning of Pop Culture is “the ways people “make do” with reigning cultural industries and institutions provide”. It means how individuals adapt to the offerings provided by cultural institutions and industries, emphasising their reactions and engagement with cultural phenomena. This concept is exemplified through blind boxes, a form of sealed packaging that conceals its contents until opened, creating an element of mystery (Zhang et al 2022), originating in Japan, which has evolved into a cultural phenomenon surrounding product consumption (Yushu Q 2022). Blind boxes initially focused on animation and subculture derivatives but have expanded to include collaborations with designers and intellectual properties. Social media platforms have been leveraged by brands to promote blind boxes, contributing to their rapid growth (Xiaolin C 2021). Research suggests that people are drawn to blind boxes due to their ability to fulfil psychological needs, such as desires for beauty, curiosity, satisfaction, and companionship, evoking nostalgic sentiments (Xiaolin C 2021). Consequently, blind boxes have gained popularity as consumers respond positively to them, often making purchases habitually (Chen B 2021).

The reason people buy blind boxes is for companions, gathering together (Xiaolin 2021), people engage with blindbox through collectibility, many blind box series are designed with collectibility in mind, each box contains a different item, creating a sense of anticipation and excitement for collectors who are eager to complete a set or find rare items. Collectors often trade duplicates with other fans to complete their collections. There is also a community on social media platforms and online forums for them to share their experiences and trade offers, they find a sense of emotional belonging (Shuichi F 2019). For example, Pop-mart's blind boxes offer unique products grouped into series and mainly happen in retail settings, online and offline (Feier L et al 2021), buyers seek to exchange duplicates, fostering a social community for trading and communication. By bridging shared interests, serving a social function, blind box social community forms (Xiaolin C 2021). This sense of community fosters camaraderie among fans who share a common interest in collecting and pop culture.

As noted in reading week 1, Pop Culture functions as a form of therapy, provides comfort, fulfils desires, and facilitates emotional release, potentially aiding individuals in coping with their circumstances (Takacs and Stacy 2015). According to research, young individuals experiencing isolation, pressure and worry, often find solace by immersing themselves in the simulated experience of blind boxes, deriving joy from the diverse figurines they encounter (Shuichi F 2019). In addition to purchasing products, they also regularly watch blind box unboxing videos. On tiktok, when searching “People Opening blind box”, there are thousands of unboxing videos of tiktokers (Tiktok 2024). Users often request additional videos or express desires for

specific collections. This fervour highlights the mystery effect of blind box purchases, as unpredictability generates positive emotions like curiosity and excitement, aligning with the positive emotion theory (Zhang et al 2022). Consequently, blind boxes serve as a means for users to recharge and alleviate stress and Blind boxes have emerged as a trend captivating people's interest and voluntary participation.

In conclusion, blind boxes exemplify Pop Culture, representing a widespread phenomenon focused on purchasing, collecting, and trading items. They offer an escape from life's pressures, fueled by social media promotion and engagement among enthusiasts.

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